



MINDFULNESS "WHAT" SKILLS – DESCRIBE BENEFITS OF DESCRIBING – WHY DESCRIBE?

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- **Describing distinguishes what IS observed from what IS NOT observed.**
"Thoughts are not facts".

Describing develops the ability to sort out and tell apart observations from mental concepts and thoughts about what we observe. Confusing mental concepts of events with events themselves (i.e. responding to thoughts and concepts as though they are facts) can lead to unnecessary emotional distress and confusion.

i.e. You hear that a good friend has several doctor's appointments in the near future and you automatically describe that as "My friend must be really sick and will die soon".

Responding to thoughts about events as though they were facts can lead to ineffective actions when the thoughts do not match the actual event.

i.e. Describing your boyfriend's not being dressed yet when you come home before going out to your birthday dinner as not loving you may ruin your chances of having a nice dinner together.

Describing is similar to CHECK THE FACTS –an emotion regulation skill.

- **Describing allows feedback from others**

Those around us can correct or validate our perceptions and descriptions of events.

i.e. After a party, one person often describes events to another and asks whether the other person saw it the same way. This can also be very important when getting consultation about interpersonal problems at work or in other settings.

i.e. Think of how children learn: They say words and parents and others correct them until they become very skilled at accurately describing what they observe.

- **Describing observations by writing them down allows observation of the information**

We learned that observing can change behavior in desired directions (remember the sleep diary or food diary example?). Describing can also at times provide a means of processing the information we have observed. Many people find journaling helpful in organizing the events they observe throughout their days.

i.e. There is research that tells us that describing and labelling emotions alone helps to regulate emotions. Brain imaging has shown that when people describe emotional responses, the very act of labelling emotions changes the brain's responses to help regulate emotions.



DESCRIBING--- WHAT TO DO:



- **Describing is adding words to an observation**

Describing is putting words to experiences or labeling what is observed. Describing follows observing. True describing involves just sticking with the facts. It may help you describe if you pretend you are instructing someone how to draw something.

i.e. Looking at a painting I could use the words "landscape", "green", "yellow" and "brush strokes" to describe what I see. It is simply applying basic descriptors to what is there.

i.e. Describing internal experience I could say - "I observe a feeling of sadness coming up"

- **If it was not observed, it cannot be described**

No one has ever observed the thoughts, intentions or emotions of another person.

Thoughts – we can observe thoughts that go through our own minds, but we can only infer or guess what another person is thinking. Assumptions of what others are thinking are just that – assumptions in our own minds.

i.e. "You disapprove" is not a description. "I think you disapprove" is a description.

i.e. "When you do X, I feel (or think) Y" is a good way to describe personal reactions to what others do or say. This connects with the DEAR MAN skill in Interpersonal Effectiveness. i.e.: "When you raise your eyebrows and purse your lips like that (X), I start thinking that you think I am lying (Y)" is a form of describing. You are describing your OWN thoughts which you can observe.

Intentions of others – no one can observe the intentions of others. Speaking about assumed intentions is not describing and can cause trouble. Intentions are very difficult to read correctly and incorrectly labeling others' intentions can be very painful. People often pay attention to the effects of what other people do and then assume that these effects were intentional.

i.e. "You are manipulating me" (not a description) → "When you tell me that you are going to quit school if I don't give you a better grade, I feel manipulated" (more accurate description).

Feelings or Emotions of others - no one can observe the feelings or emotions of another person. We can observe many outward expressions of emotion (smile, frown, postures) but we cannot observe the internal experience of emotion. Expressive behaviours can be misleading and sometimes we are wrong in our guesses about other people's emotions.

i.e. Many people may sound as if they are angry or irritated when they are very anxious.

i.e. People may withdraw from others when feeling ashamed leading others to think that they are angry.

Concepts, meanings, causes or changes in things – no one has ever directly observed these. Concepts and meanings are the results of putting together in our minds a number of observations to make sense

out of them. Causes and changes are inferred from observing the world and using logic to make deductions from our observations.

i.e. "I see you hit a ball with a cue, and the ball moves; I infer that hitting the ball caused the movement, but I did not observe "the cause" because this is a concept, not something I can directly observe".